UNIVERSITY OF CALIFORNIA, BERKELEY
HAAS SCHOOL OF BUSINESS

CHIARA MOTTA

cmotta@berkeley.edu
chimotta.github.io

CONTACT INFORMATION:

Haas School of Business
University of California, Berkeley
2220 Piedmont Avenue
Berkeley, CA 94720
+1 (341) 766-8113

DESIRED RESEARCH AND TEACHING FIELDS:

PRIMARY
- Labor Economics
- Spatial/International Trade
- Applied Microeconomics

SECONDARY
- Industrial Organization
- Applied Econometrics

FIELDS OF CONCENTRATION:

Labor Economics, Industrial Organization

DISSERTATION TITLE: "Essays on Labor Market Imperfections"

Program:	Ph.D. in Business and Public Policy, Haas School of Business
Expected Date of Completion:	May 2027
Committee:	Patrick Kline (chair), Matilde Bombardini (co-chair), Kirill Borusyak, Sydnee Caldwell, Benjamin Schoefer

PRE-DOCTORAL STUDIES:

	DEGREE	DATE	FIELD
Bocconi University	M.Sc., *summa cum laude*	2019	Economic and Social Sciences
Bocconi University	B.Sc., *summa cum laude*	2016	Economics and Social Sciences
University of British Columbia	Visiting Student	2015	

JOB MARKET PAPER:

"Can Place-Based Subsidies Improve Labor Market Efficiency?" (with Federico Cingano) [Draft]

Governments spend heavily on place-based subsidies on the premise that local labor is underutilized, yet subsidizing job creation is generally perceived as distortionary. In this paper, we explore *labor rationing*—an excess supply of workers willing to work at prevailing wages—as an understudied source of efficiency gains for such policies. We assess the empirical relevance of this mechanism in a large regional investment subsidy program in Italy. Combining application records, longitudinal firm data, matched employer–employee data, and data on contractual wage floors, we exploit the program's allocation rules at two levels. At the micro level, a regression discontinuity shows that subsidized firms expand employment with little change in average wages: incumbents work 5.5 percent more weeks at unchanged weekly wages, and wage gains are concentrated among workers paid above their contractual minima. At the market level, a recentered instrument yields no detectable wage increases or employment losses at competing firms and no change in worker mobility across labor markets. Together, these findings are consistent with employment rationing at contractual wage floors. We estimate that the efficiency gains from easing labor rationing offset 56 to 62 percent of the cost of financing the grants. Including firm owners' valuation of the grants, the marginal value of public funds is about 1.1 and falls to about 0.9 when we account for investment distortions. Workers capture only 6 to 8 percent of the program's value.

WORKING PAPERS:

"The Cost of Buying American," with Matilde Bombardini, Andres Gonzalez-Lira, and Bingjing Li. *Resubmitted, **American Economic Review*** [Draft]

The latest resurgence in the U.S. of policies aimed at reducing imports and bolstering domestic production has included the expansion of Buy American provisions. While some of these are new and untested, in this paper we evaluate the employment and welfare impact of long-standing procurement limitations on the purchase of foreign products by the U.S. Federal Government. Employing procurement micro-data, we calibrate a quantitative trade model adapted to include features relevant to the Buy American Act: a government sector, policy barriers in final and intermediate goods, labor force participation, and external economies of scale. We show that current Buy American restrictions on final goods create about 100,000 jobs at a welfare cost of about $170,000 per job. The imminent tightening of domestic-content rules for inputs to 75% creates about 86,600 jobs at a welfare cost of about $119,000 per job. We also find scant evidence of the use of Buy American rules as an effective industrial policy tool.

"*It is Never too Late*," with Filippo Palomba [Draft]

Can technology relax constraints on educational supply and expand local productive capacity? We exploit a quasi-natural experiment in postwar Italy to estimate the causal impact of educational television on adult skills and local economic activity. In 1960, the Italian public broadcaster and the Ministry of Education expanded televised adult education, with *Non è mai troppo tardi* ("It Is Never Too Late") as a flagship program—a daily literacy course supported by a national network of collective viewing centers designed to broaden access. We digitize historical records of transmitter locations and technical characteristics to predict television reception and link these predictions to industrial- and population-census data. Our effects are identified from variation in signal diffraction caused by topography, conditional on transmitter placement. We estimate stacked long differences across the 1951, 1961, and 1971 censuses for roughly 7,700 municipalities. A one-standard-deviation increase in signal strength raised adult literacy by 0.18 percentage points during the program decade relative to the preceding decade—17% of the average decadal gain. It also increased labor-force participation by 1.0 percentage point overall and 1.4 percentage points among women, and shifted employment out of agriculture. Labor-market outcomes responded to reception in neighboring municipalities within approximately 15 kilometers, consistent with local spillovers. Estimated literacy gains were larger in initially less literate municipalities and in places with collective viewing centers. Our findings suggest that broadcast technology can expand educational provision and support structural transformation, with benefits extending across municipal boundaries.

"The Labor Market Effects of Competition: Evidence from the Hudson's Bay Company," with Lukas Leucht and Davis Kedrosky [Slides]

Outside options are central to models of wage determination, but the alternatives available to workers are rarely observed directly. We study the Hudson's Bay Company (HBC), a chartered trading monopoly whose dominance in the Hudson Bay basin was challenged by the expansion of the North West Company. We digitize over a century of HBC account books, which value furs received from Indigenous trappers and goods paid in exchange in a common unit, and reconstruct the locations, ownership, and operating dates of recorded trading posts. Together, these sources allow us to measure trappers' compensation relative to the company's valuation of their output and trace how it changed as rival buyers came within reach. We find that trappers received approximately two thirds of the HBC's Standard valuation before 1770 and nearly all of it by the 1790s. Most of this increase occurred within existing posts. With post and decade fixed effects, a rival within 500 kilometers was associated with a 4.4 percentage point higher share, while proximity to other HBC posts showed no comparable association. A calibrated spatial oligopsony model connects trading terms to the geography and ownership of alternative posts and accounts for part of the observed increase.

SELECTED WORK IN PROGRESS:

"Monopsony Power Across Firms," with Sydnee Caldwell, Ingrid Haegele, and Joerg Heining

"On-the-Job Training in the Age of AI," with Jinci Liu and Dominik Wehr

"Product and Labor Market Power: Evidence from Firm-to-Firm Networks," with Eugenia Menaguale

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE:

RESEARCH:

Graduate Student Researcher, UC Berkeley	2021–2024
Visiting Researcher, Structural Economic Analysis Directorate, Bank of Italy	2022, 2025
Pre-doctoral Researcher, Bocconi University	2019–2020
Economics Intern, Competition and Markets Authority	2018
Summer Intern, European Commission (DG Competition)	2017

TEACHING:

Microeconomics (EWMBA 201A), UC Berkeley Haas (Evening/Weekend MBA) — Fall 2024, 2025, 2026

Cheit Award for Excellence in Teaching (2026) – best GSI of the Evening & Weekend MBA program, Haas School of Business
Outstanding Graduate Student Instructor Award (2026) – UC Berkeley, given to about 10% of GSIs campus-wide

Berkeley Business Academy for Youth, guest lecture, UC Berkeley Haas	Fall 2024
Microeconomics (undergraduate); Markets, Organizations and Incentives (undergraduate), Bocconi University	2019–2020
Macroeconomics (undergraduate); Macroeconomics I – Global Scenarios (graduate), Bocconi University	2019–2020

FELLOWSHIPS, HONORS, AND GRANTS:

2026	Fisher Center Research Grant
2025	University of California President's Lindau Nobel Meetings Fellow
2024, 2025	Opportunity Lab Place-Based Policy Initiative
2025	Spiller PhD Fellowship; Simpson ABD Fellowship in Global, International and Area Studies
2025	UC Berkeley IRLE Social Sciences Research Pathways; UCB Student Opportunity Fund
2024	Visiting Scholar Program, Italian Social Security Institute (INPS)
2023	Berkeley Economists for Equity Research Grant; Williamson PhD Fellowship Fund
2023	Price Theory Summer Camp, Becker Friedman Institute, University of Chicago
2020–2025	University of California, Berkeley Scholarship
2020–2022	*Marco Fanno* Scholarship, UniCredit Foundation
2022; 2020	Bank of Italy: Research Fellowship; *Donato Menichella* Scholarship (outstanding distinction)
2017–2018	IGIER Visiting Student, Bocconi University

CONFERENCES AND PRESENTATIONS:

2026	Urban Economics Association North American Meeting (Chicago; also discussant), All California Labor Economics Conference, Innsbruck Faculty Research Seminar, O-Lab Applied Microeconomics Conference on Economic Opportunity, Berkeley Labor Symposium (spring and fall*), Oliver E. Williamson Seminar, Berkeley Labor Lunch, Berkeley Trade Lunch, Berkeley Labor Seminar, New Thinking in Industrial Policy: Perspectives from Developed and Developing Countries (Columbia University)*
2025	Berkeley Labor Lunch, Berkeley Trade Lunch, OEW Student Seminar, AIEL Workshop on Labour Market Policies, Lindau Nobel Laureates Meeting, OpportunityLab Research Workshop
2024	OEW Student Seminar, Bocconi CLEAN Workshop
2023	IO Workshop, Economic History Workshop, OEW Student Seminar, Bocconi CLEAN Workshop
2022	OEW Student Seminar, Bocconi CLEAN Workshop

** scheduled*

OTHER INFORMATION:

Mentoring: *Social Science Research Pathways*
Mentoring Women in Economics
Lead The Future
Berkeley *URAP*

Programming: Stata, R, Python, LaTeX

Languages: Italian (native), English (fluent), French (basic)

REFERENCES:

Professor Patrick Kline (chair)
Department of Economics
UC Berkeley
pkline@berkeley.edu

Professor Matilde Bombardini (co-chair)
Haas School of Business
UC Berkeley
mbombardini@berkeley.edu

Professor Kirill Borusyak
Agricultural and Resource Economics
UC Berkeley
k.borusyak@berkeley.edu

Professor Sydnee Caldwell
Haas School of Business
UC Berkeley
scaldwell@berkeley.edu

Professor Benjamin Schoefer
Department of Economics
UC Berkeley
schoefer@berkeley.edu